VIJAYWADA, ANDHRA PRADESH

Like the west coast, the east coast has several mango hotspots, from Puducherry to Odisha, but no region produces and supplies as much mango across India as coastal Andhra Pradesh. The traditional mango stronghold is Vijayawada. The wealth of riches available here includes the famous Benishan, called Safeda in the north. Its flesh is firm, pale and not very sweet. It is delicately fragrant and one of the prettiest mangoes to behold. But Vijaywada is more famous for its fibrous and juicy, sucking varieties. Their names are too many, most are too difficult for the non-Telugu. Ask for Cheruku-rasala, which means the juice of sugarcane.

TRY: Nunna, Asia's largest mango market, often has on offer close to 34 mango varieties.



The Safeda

Totapuri mangoes



UMA/ALAMY

BENGALURU-KURNOOL-CHITTOOR, KARNATAKA, ANDHRA PRADESH

Northwest of India's IT capital lie numerous commercial orchards, going all the way to Hyderabad. This dry region produces the Totapuri, the main ingredient of mango pulp that goes into most mango drinks. And lots of Benishan, traded across the country. But the most famous and most prized mango from here is the Imam Pasand, a large mango with firm, fibreless flesh that is subtle in taste and fragrant in appeal. Prices remain high because of its poor productivity. The region has its fair share of delightful, sucking mangoes. And the newer varieties like Amrapali and Mallika. Mulgoa is a round, firm favourite with excellent flesh for the table, alongside the red-coloured Suvarnarekha.

TRY: Held either in May or early June, the month-long Mango Mela in Bengaluru's Lalbagh must not be missed.

VARANASI, UTTAR PRADESH

The most famous name from here is the Langra, perhaps the most prized of northern mangoes. Varanasi is known for a particularly delicate variety of the Langra with very thin skin. It still hits the back of the throat in the way a proper Langra ought to. But the fibre-free flesh is very sweet. There is also the Doodhia Langra, whitish in colour and smaller in size. Its stone is so small that it yields a surprising amount of flesh. The region also produces several other popular varieties like Chausa, Mallika and Amrapali.

Look for an uncommon variety called Gandhraj, which gets its name from its strong smell. In small amounts, it is used to embellish condiments and jams.

TRY: The Taj Nadesar Palace in Varanasi is surrounded by orchards and has its own mango festival in the season, with the best of Langra. (www.tajhotels.com)



Langras from Varanasi



Taj Nadesar